

ANTIM PANGHAL, 21
Wrestler
Hisar, Haryana

er, after having booked herself a ticket to the Asian Games and earned the title of World No. 1 in the women's 53 kg category (2025), Antim is more nimble, observant and determined. Ambition is an old friend, but resilience has joined the team. "Every bout teaches you something new, how to attack, what to pay attention to. No two opponents are the same," she says. "When we train, we learn how to not get too confident if we win and not too disheartened if we lose."

Her routine is much the same as it was when she started training as a 10-year-old. Get up at six in the morning, train for three to four hours, repeat in the evening. She looks back on the journey that started with travelling 20 km daily to practise, and wears her setbacks like badges of honour. "Give it your all, with everything you have," she tells youngsters. "The best advice I got was to not lose sight of your goals, no matter what happens, to not back off for a single day." ■

— Udbhav Seth